

TCS NQT Tier 1 Masterclass: Core Grammar & Verbal Ability

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May 28, 2026

Introduction from the Examiner

Welcome to Tier 1 of the Verbal Ability section. These are your "ROI Boosters." In the TCS NQT, Error Spotting and Sentence Correction carry the maximum weightage. The secret to clearing these in 30 seconds is to stop reading for "flow" or "feel." TCS specifically writes incorrect sentences that sound perfectly normal in spoken English.

You must read like a scanner. Look for the Subject, find the Verb, check the Preposition, and verify the Tense. Below are the exact shortcuts, the internal traps we use to confuse you, and 40 high-priority questions separated by your requested topics.

1 Subject-Verb Agreement

Tricks, Steps & Shortcuts

- **The "First Subject" Rule:** When two subjects are joined by words like *as well as*, *along with*, *together with*, *in addition to*, *besides*, *except*, the verb must ALWAYS agree with the FIRST subject.
- **The "Nearest Subject" Rule:** When two subjects are joined by *Either...or*, *Neither...nor*, *Not only...but also*, *or*, *nor*, the verb must agree with the subject NEAREST to it.
- **The "One of the" Rule:** "One of the" is always followed by a PLURAL noun, but takes a SINGULAR verb. (e.g., One of the *boys is* missing).

TCS Traps to Avoid

- **The Distance Trap:** We will put a long, plural phrase between a singular subject and its verb to trick your ear. *Trap:* "The box of chocolates are missing." *Truth:* The subject is "box" (singular). It should be "The box of chocolates *is* missing."
- **Plural-Sounding Subjects:** Words like *Mathematics*, *News*, *Physics*, *Measles*, *Innings*, *Summons* look plural because of the 's', but they take a SINGULAR verb.

Top 10 High Priority Questions

1. **Question:** Find the error: The captain, along with his team members, are going to the stadium.
Solution: Error is in "are going". It should be "is going".

Explanation: Apply the First Subject Rule. "along with" connects "captain" (singular) and "team members". The verb must agree with "captain".

2. **Question:** Find the error: Neither the manager nor the employees was aware of the new policy.
Solution: Error is in "was aware". It should be "were aware".
Explanation: Apply the Nearest Subject Rule. With "Neither...nor", the verb agrees with the closest subject. The closest subject is "employees" (plural).
3. **Question:** Fill in the blank: The jury ____ divided in their opinion.
A) is B) are C) has D) have
Solution: B) are
Explanation: Collective nouns take a singular verb when acting as one unit. But when they are "divided" or acting individually, they take a plural verb.
4. **Question:** Find the error: One of the most intelligent student in the class has failed the exam.
Solution: Error is in "student". It should be "students".
Explanation: The phrase "One of the" must always be followed by a plural noun (students), though the verb remains singular (has).
5. **Question:** Find the error: A great many student have passed the TCS NQT this year.
Solution: Error is in "student". It should be "students".
Explanation: The phrase "A great many" is always followed by a plural noun and a plural verb.
6. **Question:** Fill in the blank: Each of the boys ____ given a laptop.
A) was B) were C) have D) are
Solution: A) was
Explanation: Words like Each, Every, Everyone, Someone, Nobody always take a singular verb.
7. **Question:** Find the error: Ten miles are a long distance to walk on foot.
Solution: Error is in "are". It should be "is".
Explanation: Plural numbers representing a specific quantity, distance, time, or amount as a whole unit take a singular verb.
8. **Question:** Find the error: The number of applicants for the job are very large this year.
Solution: Error is in "are". It should be "is".
Explanation: "The number of" takes a singular verb. (Note: "A number of" takes a plural verb).
9. **Question:** Find the error: Bread and butter are my favorite breakfast.
Solution: Error is in "are". It should be "is".
Explanation: When two singular nouns joined by 'and' refer to the same person or a single idea/dish, the verb is singular.
10. **Question:** Fill in the blank: The committee ____ issued its report.
A) have B) are C) has D) were
Solution: C) has
Explanation: The committee is acting as a single, unified body (indicated by the singular pronoun "its"). Therefore, it takes a singular verb.
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2 Prepositions & Conjunctions

Tricks, Steps & Shortcuts

- **Correlative Pairs:** Always check if the pairs match perfectly. *Hardly/Scarcely* pairs with *when*. *No sooner* pairs with *than*. *Though/Although* pairs with *yet* (or a comma). *Lest* pairs with *should*.
- **Parallelism Rule:** In conjunctions like "Not only... but also", the grammar structure after both parts must be identical. (e.g., Not only *to run* but also *to swim*).
- **Fixed Prepositions:** Some verbs only take specific prepositions. Memorize the high-frequency ones: addicted *to*, prefer *to*, insist *on*, refrain *from*, comply *with*.

TCS Traps to Avoid

- **The Superfluous Preposition Trap:** TCS adds prepositions where none are needed to trick your ear. *Trap words:* "Discuss about", "Order for", "Emphasize on", "Despite of". None of these take a preposition in standard grammar! (Correct: Discuss the matter, Despite the rain).
- **The "Between vs Among" Trap:** Use "between" for exactly two entities. Use "among" for more than two.

Top 10 High Priority Questions

1. **Question:** Find the error: Despite of the heavy rain, she managed to reach the office on time.
Solution: Remove "of".
Explanation: "Despite" never takes the preposition "of". You can either use "Despite" alone, or "In spite of".
2. **Question:** Find the error: No sooner had the teacher entered the class when the students stood up.
Solution: Replace "when" with "than".
Explanation: Correlative conjunction rule: "No sooner" must ALWAYS be followed by "than". "Hardly/Scarcely" is followed by "when".
3. **Question:** Fill in the blank: I prefer reading books ____ watching television.
A) than B) over C) to D) against
Solution: C) to
Explanation: The verb "prefer" is always followed by the preposition "to", not "than". Same applies to words like senior, junior, prior, superior.
4. **Question:** Find the error: The committee will discuss about the new project tomorrow.
Solution: Remove "about".
Explanation: The verb "discuss" means "to talk about". Adding "about" makes it redundant. It should be "discuss the new project."
5. **Question:** Fill in the blank: He has been suffering from fever ____ Monday.
A) from B) since C) for D) on
Solution: B) since
Explanation: "Since" is used for a specific point in time (Monday, 1999, morning). "For" is used for a duration (for two days, for three years).

6. **Question:** Find the error: Walk carefully lest you may fall down.
Solution: Replace "may" with "should".
Explanation: The conjunction "lest" (which means 'to avoid the risk of') must always be followed by the modal verb "should".
7. **Question:** Find the error: This secret must remain between you and I.
Solution: Replace "I" with "me".
Explanation: Prepositions (like "between") must always be followed by the objective case of a pronoun. It must be "between you and me."
8. **Question:** Fill in the blank: She insisted _____ going to the party.
A) for B) on C) in D) to
Solution: B) on
Explanation: Fixed preposition rule. The verb "insist" is always followed by the preposition "on" (and an -ing verb/gerund).
9. **Question:** Find the error: He is not only famous in India but also in America.
Solution: Shift the position: "He is famous not only in India but also in America."
Explanation: Parallelism rule. "But also" is followed by a prepositional phrase ("in America"). Therefore, "not only" must also be placed directly before the prepositional phrase ("in India").
10. **Question:** Find the error: The property was divided between the four brothers.
Solution: Replace "between" with "among".
Explanation: "Between" is used for two people. For more than two (four brothers), "among" must be used.
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3 Tenses & Modals

Tricks, Steps & Shortcuts

- **The Past Perfect Rule (Two actions in the past):** If two actions happened in the past, the older action takes the Past Perfect (*had* + V3), and the newer action takes the Simple Past (V2).
- **The Third Conditional (The TCS Favorite):** Structure: **If** + Subject + **had** + V3 (past perfect), Subject + **would have** + V3.
- **Modal Baseline:** Modals (will, would, can, could, shall, should, may, might, must) are ALWAYS followed by the base form of the verb (V1). Never use V2 or V3 directly after a modal.

TCS Traps to Avoid

- **The "Did" Trap:** We will write "He did not went there." Remember, "do, does, did" ALWAYS take the base verb (V1). It must be "He did not go."
- **The Imaginary "If" Trap:** When dealing with wishes or imaginary situations (e.g., "If I was the PM"), standard grammar breaks. You must ALWAYS use "were" for all subjects in imaginary conditionals. "If I *were* the PM."

Top 10 High Priority Questions

1. **Question:** Find the error: The train left the station before I reached there.
Solution: Replace "left" with "had left".
Explanation: Two past actions. The train leaving is the older action, so it must be in the Past Perfect tense (had + V3). Reaching the station is the second action (Simple Past).
2. **Question:** Find the error: If I would have studied harder, I would have passed the exam.
Solution: Replace "would have studied" with "had studied".
Explanation: Third Conditional rule. The "If" clause cannot contain "would have". It must be "If + Past Perfect" (If I had studied), followed by the main clause "would have + V3".
3. **Question:** Fill in the blank: I wish I ____ a millionaire.
A) am B) was C) were D) have been
Solution: C) were
Explanation: In subjunctive mood (expressing a wish or unreal condition), "were" is used with all subjects (I, he, she, it).
4. **Question:** Find the error: He did not submitted the assignment on time.
Solution: Replace "submitted" with "submit".
Explanation: The auxiliary verb "did" already indicates the past tense. It must be followed by the base form of the verb (V1).
5. **Question:** Fill in the blank: By next year, I ____ from college.
A) will graduate B) have graduated C) will have graduated D) graduate
Solution: C) will have graduated
Explanation: The phrase "By next year" indicates an action that will be completed before a specific time in the future. This requires the Future Perfect tense.
6. **Question:** Find the error: She has completed her graduation in 2021.
Solution: Replace "has completed" with "completed".
Explanation: When a specific past time is given (in 2021, yesterday, last week), you must use Simple Past tense, NOT Present Perfect.
7. **Question:** Fill in the blank: You ____ obey the traffic rules.
A) can B) might C) must D) could
Solution: C) must
Explanation: "Must" expresses strong obligation or duty, which is grammatically and logically required for traffic rules.
8. **Question:** Find the error: It is high time you start preparing for the NQT.
Solution: Replace "start" with "started".
Explanation: The phrases "It is time" or "It is high time" are followed by a subject and a verb in the Simple Past tense (V2), even though they refer to the present.
9. **Question:** Find the error: I am knowing him for a long time.
Solution: Replace "am knowing" with "have known".
Explanation: Stative verbs (like know, love, hate, understand) are generally not used in the continuous (-ing) form. Since there is a duration ("for a long time"), Present Perfect is correct.
10. **Question:** Find the error: If it will rain, I will cancel the trip.
Solution: Replace "will rain" with "rains".
Explanation: First Conditional rule. In a likely future situation, the "If" clause takes the Simple Present tense, and the main clause takes the Simple Future.

4 Articles & Nouns

Tricks, Steps & Shortcuts

- **The Sound Rule for A/An:** Do not look at the first letter (vowel vs consonant). Listen to the SOUND. If the word starts with a vowel sound (a, e, i, o, u sound in Hindi/English), use 'An'. If it starts with a consonant sound (even if the letter is a vowel like 'U' sounding like 'Yoo'), use 'A'.
- **Uncountable Nouns Rule:** Some nouns cannot be counted. They never take an 's' to become plural, and they never take 'A' or 'An' before them.
- **Specific vs General:** Use 'The' when referring to a specific item both the speaker and listener know about.

TCS Traps to Avoid

- **The Fake Plural Trap:** TCS will add an 's' to uncountable nouns. Words like *Scenery, Poetry, Furniture, Advice, Information, Luggage, Mischief* NEVER take an 's'. (e.g., "He gave me many advices" is WRONG. It is "pieces of advice").
- **The University/European Trap:** "European" starts with an 'E', but sounds like "Yoo-ropean" (Y consonant sound). So it is "A European", not "An European". Same for "A University", "A One-eyed man".
- **The Honest/Hour Trap:** "Honest" starts with an 'H', but the 'H' is silent. It sounds like "On-est". So it is "An honest man".

Top 10 High Priority Questions

1. **Question:** Find the error: I packed all my luggages for the trip.
Solution: Replace "luggages" with "luggage".
Explanation: "Luggage" is an uncountable noun. It never takes an 's'.
2. **Question:** Fill in the blank: He is ____ European by birth.
A) a B) an C) the D) no article
Solution: A) a
Explanation: The word "European" starts with a 'Y' sound (Yoo). Therefore, it takes the article 'a', not 'an'.
3. **Question:** Find the error: She gave me an information regarding the upcoming TCS exam.
Solution: Remove "an" or replace with "a piece of".
Explanation: "Information" is an uncountable noun. You cannot use indefinite articles (a/an) directly before it.
4. **Question:** Fill in the blank: He is ____ honest man and will not lie.
A) a B) an C) the D) no article
Solution: B) an
Explanation: The 'h' in honest is silent. It starts with a vowel sound (on-est). Thus, 'an' is used.

5. **Question:** Find the error: The sceneries of Kashmir are very beautiful.
Solution: Replace "sceneries of Kashmir are" with "scenery of Kashmir is".
Explanation: "Scenery" is an uncountable noun. It cannot be made plural (sceneries). Being singular, it must take a singular verb (is).
6. **Question:** Find the error: I have bought some new furnitures for my house.
Solution: Replace "furnitures" with "furniture".
Explanation: "Furniture" is an uncountable noun and does not have a plural form ending in 's'.
7. **Question:** Fill in the blank: ____ sun rises in the east.
A) A B) An C) The D) No article
Solution: C) The
Explanation: We use the definite article "the" before unique celestial bodies and natural phenomena (the sun, the moon, the earth, the sky).
8. **Question:** Find the error: English is spoken by English.
Solution: Add "the" before the second "English". "English is spoken by the English."
Explanation: "English" refers to the language. "The English" refers to the people of England. When referring to a nation or community as a whole, use "the".
9. **Question:** Find the error: My cousin brother is arriving today from Delhi.
Solution: Remove "brother".
Explanation: "Cousin" already implies a relative. It is grammatically incorrect to say "cousin brother" or "cousin sister" in standard English. Just say "My cousin is arriving."
10. **Question:** Fill in the blank: He studies in ____ university in Mumbai.
A) a B) an C) the D) no article
Solution: A) a
Explanation: "University" starts with a 'Y' consonant sound (Yoo-ni-versity). Therefore, it takes the article 'a'.